

Ups-and-Downs Marked 25 Polar Seasons Here

By CLELL BUZZELL

The date was May 4, 1933. It was in the depths of the great depression when a national farm strike threatened and Daffodil Dresses sold for 49 cents at The Kepler Co., if you had the money.

At 4 p.m. on sand - swept Chappell Field near Davis Beach on the old Chippewa highway, the cry of "Play Ball!" rang out.

SO BEGAN the first season of Northern League baseball in Eau Claire, the first organized ball in 21 years since the old Wisconsin-Minnesota League had disbanded in 1912.

Mayor Fred Stussy threw the first pitch. Catching it was the late Glen Rork, president of the Chamber of Commerce.

Eau Claire's team, managed by Johnny Mostil, and called the Cardinals, lost the opener to East Grand Forks, 11-4. A crowd of 2,000, mostly avoiding the 40 cent admission because fences weren't completed, saw the debut of Owner Dave Quinn's team.

SUNDAY, 27 years later, Eau Claire will open its 25th anniversary season of Northern League baseball in beautiful Carson Park. The city has had an entry in every one of the 24 previous seasons.

It took Eau Claire 10 seasons to win its first pennant in 1942. But Eau Claire now leads the circuit in number of championships with five.

Eau Claire's entry became Bears in the early years of the league, featuring a brand name of the Gillette Tire Co. In 1954 it became the Braves to coincide with the long affiliation with the Boston and Milwaukee Braves.

The club struggled through many a crisis in the lean years of the 1930's dealing mostly with the Chicago Cubs. Rescued from near-collapse by the Junior Chamber of Commerce in 1941, the Bears enjoyed two fine seasons as Minneapolis Miller affiliates.

REORGANIZED as a community enterprise after World War II, the club joined forces with the Milwaukee Brewers in 1946 and went along to the Boston organization when the Braves bought the Brewers in the deal which ultimately brought major league ball to Wisconsin.

The tieup with Boston and Milwaukee proved ideal. Eau Claire won four championships in the 13-year affiliation and has had only four second division clubs.

Besides riding the crest of great minor league baseball popularity in the late 1940's, the Eau Claire club survived both the difficult early years when the league operated almost literally on a shoestring and the period of minor league retrenchment in the 1950's which has seen more

EAU CLAIRE RECORDS				
Date-Manager	W	L	Pos	
1923-Johnny Mostil	52	45	Third	
1934-Johnny Mostil	63	58	Fourth	
1935-Johnny Mostil	52	63	Fifth	
1936-Johnny Mostil	67	52	Second	
1937-Johnny Mostil	65	53	Third	
1938-Ed Garrity	39	84	Eighth	
1939-Ivy Griffin	56	60	Fourth	
1940-Ivy Griffin	42	70	Eighth	
1941-Rosy Ryan	60	52	Fourth	
1942-Rosy Ryan	81	41	First	
1943-Joe Skurski	56	52	Fourth	
1947-Hugh Wise	62	57	Fifth	
1948-Andy Cohen	66	55	Third	
1949-Andy Cohen	71	52	First	
1950-Andy Cohen	73	53	Second	
1951-Bill Adair	77	44	First	
1952-Bill Adair	72	53	Third	
1953-Bill Carr	49	77	Eighth	
1954-Charley Root	71	63	Fourth	
1955-Joe Just	81	43	First	
1956-Joe Just	70	52	First	
1957-G. Maltzberger	70	55	Third	
1958-G. Maltzberger	65	56	Fifth	
1959-T. Jackson	55	68	Seventh	

than half of its members fall by the wayside.

MAGIC NAMES in the baseball world have made stops here. In pre-world War II days they included Mostil, Hank Majeski, Stan Sperry, Phil Masi, Clint Hartung and Wes Westrum. Since 1946 there have been Jim Del-sing, Bill Bruton, Andy Cohen, Bill Adair, Hank Aaron, and Wes Covington, just to name a few.

Eau Claire's own athletes and those from nearby communities have added more than one chapter to the city's Northern League story. Andy Pakko of Boyceville and Vic Johnson, Hod Hoepfner and Don Jordan of Eau Claire are a few who come to mind. Hud Gelein is carrying on the tradition.

The baseball played today isn't too different from the game in 1933, even though organization and facilities are much changed. Some club records set in the first few years of the league still stand.

Mostil scouted out most of his own players in the early years of the league, then peddled the better ones to any higher club interested. Trades with other teams in the circuit were common.

FARM SYSTEM baseball appeared under Manager Ivy Griffin in 1939-40 in a tieup with the Madison Blues and Milwaukee Brewers. It took another step in two years with the Minneapolis Millers.

After World War II, the farm system took over. Eau Claire worked one season with the Milwaukee Brewers, then followed them into the Boston Braves chain and has been there ever since.

Teams now come ready-made from Milwaukee's minor league camp at Waycross, Ga., the products of selective scouting and training. Eau Claire furnishes the facilities and fans, Milwaukee the manager and players.

Eau Claire made the switch from Chappell Field to Carson Park in 1937. The \$50,000 park was hailed as one of the finest Class D fields in the nation. Its original lighting system has been completely replaced and many improvements made in grandstand fa-

cilities for players and fans alike.

TWO EAU CLAIRE teams share the honor of having won the most games in a season. Manager Rosy Ryan's 1942 champions and Manager Joe Just's 1955 pennant winners both copped 81 games. The 1942 team had the top percentage of .664 with 41 losses.

Low ebb of Eau Claire fortunes was Manager Ed Garrity's 1938 team which won 39 games and lost 84.

Eau Claire's 24 Northern League seasons have produced five pennant winners, while no other member has gained more than three championships. Eau Claire has also had three second-place teams, four in third three in fifth, one in seventh and three in eighth. Two Eau Claire teams won playoff championships.

Eau Claire's teams have produced two league batting champions. Horace Garner with .359 and 1951 and Manuel Jimenez with .340 in 1958, and one home run king, Harry Hanebrink with 16 in 1948.

EAU CLAIRE'S club leaders have set marks that will be hard to break. Majeski holds the batting record with a .365 average in 1936. He shares the home run leadership with Tommy Aaron at 26. Henry Myers leads in runs batted in with 129 in 1936.

Eau Claire pitchers have led the league in won-loss percentage four times. Ralph Mead had 11-4 in 1934, Bob Botz 13-3 in 1955, Bob Dudley 14-6 in 1956 and Ernie Christoff 15-4 in 1958. Botz' .813 percentage is best in the club's history.

Two Eau Claire hurlers have paced the league in earned run averages kept since 1939. Bob Eisenach had a 2.17 mark in 1946 and George Yorke 2.06 in 1949. Yorke's was the best ERA figure in club history.

Chuck Henry's 184 strikeouts in 1948 are high for any Eau Claire pitcher. His total and Georges Maranda's 179 in 1954 are the only two times Eau Claire hurlers led the league in strikeouts.

HERMAN D. WHITE, who helped put the Eau Claire club on a sound basis in the early years, became league president in 1935 and served every year since then except for a two-year "retirement" in 1958-59. He's back at the helm of the circuit which he helped make one of the strongest in minor league ball.

R. B. Bezanson, who stepped out as Eau Claire Braves president after last season, guided the club through more than a decade of its Braves tieup. Other leading officials included G. Otis Linderman, Charley Wachendorfer, Eddie Stumpf, Bob Tarleton, Norm Macht, and Bob Quinn.